

Research Progress

What I Learned from “The Byzantine Generals Problem”

Chiharu Tomimori

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Why I Studied This Topic

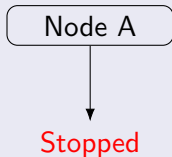
- I studied Paxos.
- I wanted to clarify the difference between crash faults and Byzantine faults.
- I also wanted to understand why PBFT requires $3f + 1$ replicas.
- Therefore, I read “[The Byzantine Generals Problem](#)” as theoretical background.

Main Purpose

My goal was not only to read the paper, but to understand the foundation of Byzantine Fault Tolerance.

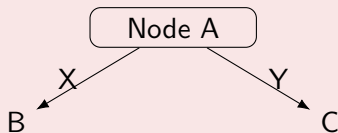
My Understanding of Fault Models

Crash Fault



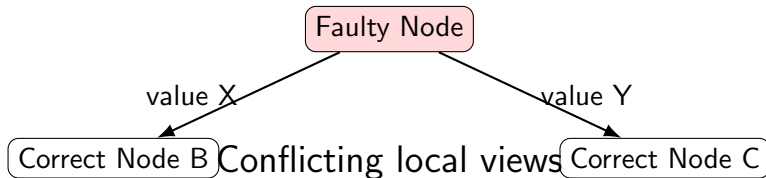
- Stops responding
- Easier to detect
- Paxos / Raft
- $2f + 1$ replicas

Byzantine Fault



- Behaves arbitrarily
- Sends conflicting messages
- PBFT / BFT protocols
- $3f + 1$ replicas

The Core Problem I Understood



Key Insight

The main problem is not identifying the faulty node. The main problem is guaranteeing that correct nodes still make the same decision.

My Understanding of the $3f + 1$ Requirement

For $f = 1$

- 3 nodes are not enough.
- 4 nodes are required.
- Correct nodes need enough independent reports.

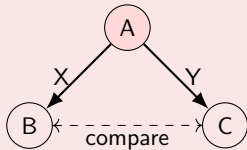
Byzantine Faults	Required Nodes
0	1
1	4
2	7
3	10

Important Realization

PBFT's $3f + 1$ requirement is not just an implementation choice. It comes from a fundamental impossibility result.

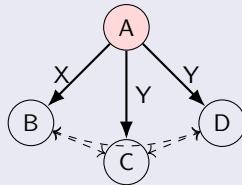
Why 3 Nodes Are Not Enough, But 4 Nodes Are

3 Nodes: Ambiguous



B sees X from A and Y from C. It cannot know who is faulty.

4 Nodes: More Evidence



Correct nodes can compare reports from more independent nodes.

My Understanding

With only 3 nodes, one Byzantine node can create an indistinguishable conflict. With 4 nodes, correct nodes have enough additional reports to overcome one faulty node.

What I Understand Now

Current Understanding

- Byzantine faults are stronger than crash faults.
- The goal is agreement among correct nodes.
- Identifying the faulty node is not the primary goal.
- $3f + 1$ replicas are necessary.

PBFT Intuition

- Do not trust the leader alone.
- Share proposals among replicas.
- Require enough matching messages.
- Preserve safety despite faulty replicas.

Next Steps

- ① Read *Practical Byzantine Fault Tolerance*.
- ② Focus on the system model and normal-case protocol.
- ③ Trace one request with $f = 1$ and four replicas.
- ④ Implement a small PBFT simulator.
- ⑤ Compare PBFT with Paxos, Raft, and HotStuff.

Byzantine Fault Tolerance is about building a consistent shared decision even when some nodes provide conflicting information.

What I Gained

This study gave me the theoretical basis for understanding why PBFT uses $3f + 1$ replicas and multiple communication phases.